

"I'm frightened! I don't know what's going to happen, and so I'm looking for somewhere else to live." This was how a Rotorua woman reacted when a "geyser" ripped through the middle of her front lawn recently.

There are a lot of natural hot water springs in the quiet street, and they had been very active for a few weeks. Not long before the big outburst, a patch of ground had given way beneath the man who mowed the lawns. He fell through into a muddy hole. He wasn't injured, but he was certainly shaken. No one was surprised when he refused to return.

The Case of the Eru

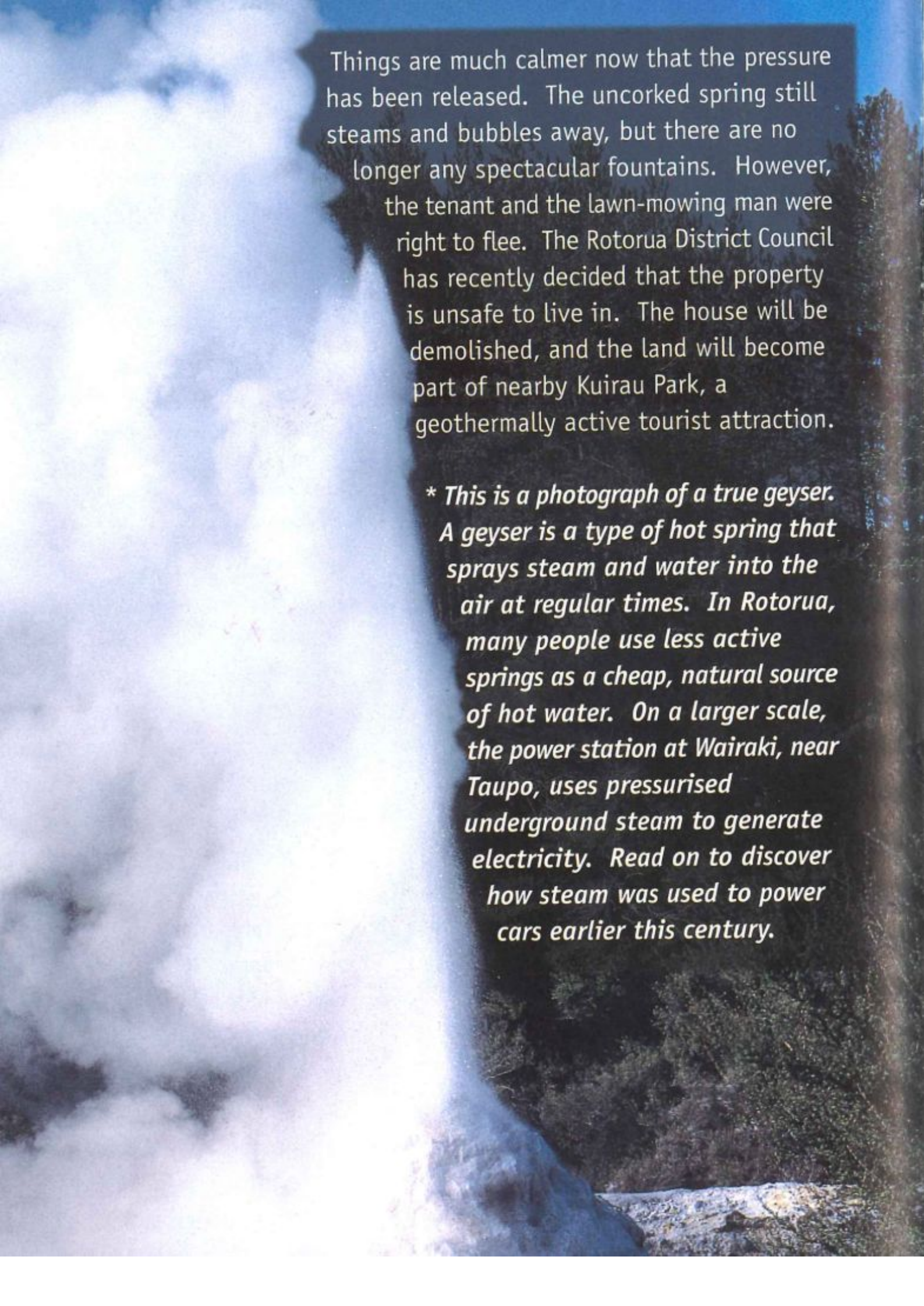
pting Lawn

by Rupert Alchin



But the really big eruption started on Friday, 8 May 1998. Late in the afternoon, a scalding fountain burst from the ground, hurling mud, steam, hot water, and rocks into the air. By Sunday afternoon, it was spraying as high as 12 metres. Residents were terrified, but fascinated tourists and geologists flocked to the scene.

It was later discovered that what was thought to be a new geyser* was in fact a normal hot spring. A long time before, the spring had been filled in by locals. (This explained the fact that as well as earth and water, old bottles were being thrown from the vent!) Over the years, pressure built up in the buried spring, which finally blew its top.



Things are much calmer now that the pressure has been released. The uncorked spring still steams and bubbles away, but there are no longer any spectacular fountains. However, the tenant and the lawn-mowing man were right to flee. The Rotorua District Council has recently decided that the property is unsafe to live in. The house will be demolished, and the land will become part of nearby Kuirau Park, a geothermally active tourist attraction.

** This is a photograph of a true geyser. A geyser is a type of hot spring that sprays steam and water into the air at regular times. In Rotorua, many people use less active springs as a cheap, natural source of hot water. On a larger scale, the power station at Wairaki, near Taupo, uses pressurised underground steam to generate electricity. Read on to discover how steam was used to power cars earlier this century.*